Rs 25,000. The new tax regime rate structure has also been revised to offer salaried employees benefits of up to Rs 17,500 in income tax.

REGIME FOR THE RICH?

A good part of 2023 was overshadowed by short-seller Hindenburg's allegations against the Adani Group. Closer to the general election, the issue of electoral bonds erupted, with the Supreme Court issuing a diktat to the State Bank of India to make all bond purchaser data public through the Election Commission of India's portal. Although the Opposition struggled to gain political traction from this issue during the election, the perception of the Modi government favouring big business has remained a stigma. According to 58.3 per cent of the respondents, it is big business that benefits the most from the Modi government's economic policies, while only around 29 per cent believe that small businesses, farmers, the salaried class and daily wage earners have benefitted. Interestingly, despite this, the perception that the Modi government has managed to reduce corruption in India remains high, with nearly 56 per cent of those polled holding this view. This marks a significant increase from the 46.2 per cent who expressed the same sentiment in the previous MOTN.

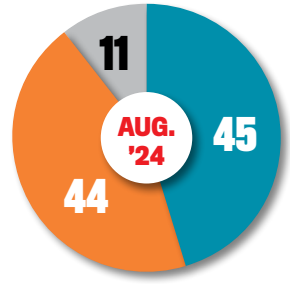
The public continues to believe that the government should exit the business of running businesses. A majority—56.3 per cent of the respondents in the MOTN survey—want the Centre to divest its stake in loss-making public sector units. However, the Centre is expected to proceed cautiously, as privatising state-owned units could provoke a political storm, which the government may wish to avoid in the early days of Modi 3.0. Consequently, many think the government will adhere to the February interim budget's disinvestment target of Rs 30,000 crore, which was much lower than the previously budgeted Rs 51,000 crore.

Despite being an outlier on the world stage in terms of growth, India's economy continues to pose several challenges for the government, particularly because it is still growing below its potential. Only a sustained, faster growth can significantly boost jobs and incomes, an imperative that the ruling dispensation must deliver in the months to come. ■

78%

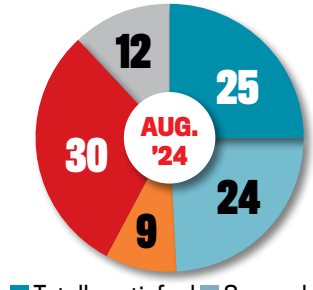
of the respondents consider the unemployment situation in India as serious, up from 71% in February

Q. Do you think Budget 2024 will generate jobs as projected?



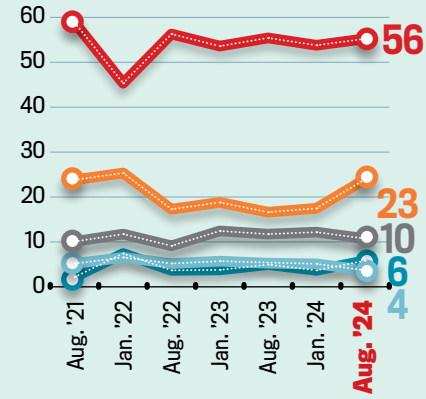
People are split on whether Budget 2024 will create the projected employment

Q. Are you satisfied with the income tax changes in Budget 2024?

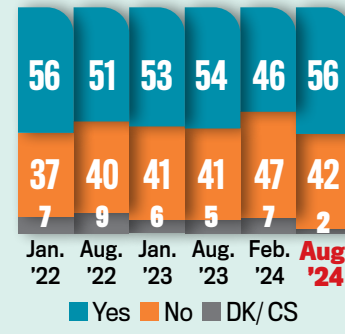


Many approve of the income tax rule changes in this year's budget

Q. How do you view the unemployment situation in the country?



Q. Has the Modi government been able to reduce corruption in India?



The belief in Modi govt's reduction of corruption is back after a dip in the previous MOTN

All figures in % and rounded off